PUNJABI COLLECTION

NO. 05



MUGHLAI-PUNJABI ORIGIN

Shahi Paneer

Royal Cashew & Cream Paneer Curry

A Milder, Regal Cousin of Butter Paneer

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Shahi Paneer

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

A Dish Named for Royalty

The word "shahi" means royal in Hindi and Urdu, and shahi paneer earns the title honestly — it's a curry built around cashews, cream, and warm whole spices rather than the tomato-forward tang of butter paneer, giving it a milder, more mellow richness that traces its lineage to Mughlai court cooking traditions, where nut-based gravies and delicate spicing were hallmarks of royal kitchens.

Where butter paneer built its identity in the tandoor-and-tomato tradition of Delhi's post-Partition restaurant kitchens, shahi paneer draws more directly from older Mughlai techniques — a reminder that Punjabi and North Indian cuisine is itself a blend of Persian-influenced Mughal court cooking and heartier Punjabi farmhouse traditions, with different dishes leaning toward one influence or the other.

The result is a curry that's often mistaken for butter paneer by newcomers to Indian food, but connoisseurs know the difference immediately: shahi paneer's gravy is paler, creamier, and rounder in flavor, built on the sweetness of cashews and onions rather than the bright acidity of tomatoes.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

A Dish Named for Royalty, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Rooted in Mughlai court cooking traditions, distinct from the more tomato-forward Delhi restaurant lineage of butter paneer. Considered a more refined, special-occasion dish, often served at weddings and formal Punjabi gatherings. A popular choice for guests who prefer a milder, less tangy curry than butter paneer or paneer lababdar. Frequently garnished with silvered almonds or pistachios, echoing its royal Mughlai heritage.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

15m	30m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Small saucepan, for boiling the cashews and onion
- Blender
- Kadai or wide pan for the gravy
- Fine sieve — optional, for extra-smooth texture

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Shahi paneer keeps refrigerated for 3–4 days. It freezes reasonably well for up to a month, though the cream-based gravy may separate slightly on thawing — stir well while reheating gently over low heat, and consider adding a splash of fresh cream after reheating to restore silkiness.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the gravy base

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Cashews, raw	½ cup	70 g	½ katori
Onion, roughly chopped	1 large	150 g	1 large
Water, for boiling	1 cup	240 ml	1 katori
Whole spices: green cardamom, cloves, cinnamon stick	2, 3, 1 inch	2, 3, 1 inch	2, 3, 1 inch
Ghee or butter	3 tbsp	45 g	3 chammach
Ginger-garlic paste	1 tbsp	15 g	1 chammach
Tomato puree	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach
Kashmiri red chili powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Sugar	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste

To finish

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Paneer, cubed	300 g	300 g	300 g
Heavy cream	¼ cup	60 ml	¼ katori
Silvered almonds, for garnish	2 tbsp	15 g	2 tbsp
Saffron strands — optional	a pinch	a pinch	a pinch

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Cashews are essential to this dish's character and don't have a close substitute — if allergic, blanched almonds can work in a pinch, though the flavor shifts noticeably. Saffron is a lovely traditional touch but purely optional and can be omitted without significantly changing the dish. As with butter paneer, firm tofu can substitute for paneer, though the texture and flavor will differ from the traditional dairy version.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Building the Gravy Base

01 BOIL THE CASHEWS AND ONION

Combine the cashews, roughly chopped onion, and water in a small saucepan. Bring to a boil and simmer for 10 minutes, until the onion is soft and the cashews have softened slightly.

02 BLEND TO A SMOOTH PASTE

Let cool slightly, then blend the cashew-onion mixture with the boiling liquid to a completely smooth, pale paste. For the silkiest texture, pass through a fine sieve.



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Building the Gravy Base, continued

03 BLOOM THE WHOLE SPICES

Heat ghee in a kadai and add the whole cardamom, cloves, and cinnamon stick, letting them sizzle gently for about 30 seconds until fragrant.

Chef tip. whole spices bloomed in ghee at the very start build a much deeper aromatic base than adding ground spices alone.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The cashew-onion paste should be completely smooth with no graininess, and pale ivory in color — this is the base that gives shahi paneer its signature mellow richness.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Finishing the Curry

04 ADD AROMATICS AND TOMATO

Add the ginger-garlic paste to the bloomed whole spices, cooking until fragrant, then stir in the tomato puree and cook for 3–4 minutes until it darkens slightly.

05 ADD THE CASHEW PASTE

Pour in the cashew-onion paste, along with the chili powder, sugar, and salt. Simmer for 10–12 minutes, stirring frequently since the nut-based gravy can catch on the bottom of the pan more easily than a tomato-based one.

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Finishing the Curry, continued



06 ADD PANEER AND CREAM

Gently fold in the paneer cubes and simmer for 3–4 minutes until warmed through. Stir in the cream and saffron if using, and simmer for another minute.

Color indicator. finished shahi paneer should be a pale golden-ivory color, noticeably lighter than butter paneer's deep orange-red.

07 GARNISH AND SERVE

Top with silvered almonds just before serving, for both flavor and the dish's traditional royal presentation.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Finishing the Curry, continued

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Cooking the cashew-based gravy over high heat is a common cause of scorching, since nut-based sauces catch more easily than tomato ones. Keep the heat medium-low and stir frequently.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served with naan or paratha, letting the mellow, creamy gravy contrast with a simple bread.
- A common choice at weddings and formal Punjabi gatherings, prized for its refined, less tangy flavor.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a bowl with a scatter of silvered almonds and a light dusting of saffron threads on top.

Family Style

- Served alongside butter paneer or dal makhani for guests who prefer a milder option at the same meal.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Richness Right

- Boiling the cashews before blending, rather than blending them raw, gives a noticeably smoother, silkier gravy.
- A light hand with tomato is essential — too much and the dish starts to taste like butter paneer instead of its own distinct self.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- The cashew-onion paste can be made up to 2 days ahead and refrigerated, speeding up final cooking significantly.
- Add paneer and cream fresh each time you reheat, rather than storing them cooked together for extended periods.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some kitchens finish the dish with a few drops of rose water for an extra-fragrant, distinctly Mughlai touch — a subtle detail worth experimenting with for special occasions.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

365 kcal	12 g	13 g	30 g	2 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with cream, butter, and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Tree nuts. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Shahi Paneer with Saffron Milk	an extra-luxurious version using saffron-infused milk instead of plain cream.
Shahi Korma-Style	a close cousin, sometimes made with mixed vegetables instead of paneer.
Lighter Shahi Paneer	using less cream and cashews for a lower-fat, everyday version.

What's the real difference between this and butter paneer?

Shahi paneer uses far less tomato and relies primarily on cashews and onions for its base, giving a paler, milder, creamier gravy compared to butter paneer's tangier, tomato-forward orange-red curry.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Why did my gravy turn grainy?

Usually not blending the cashew-onion mixture long enough, or skipping the sieving step. Blend thoroughly and strain if you want a restaurant-smooth texture.

Can I make this less rich?

Yes — reduce the cashews slightly and use half-and-half or whole milk instead of heavy cream for a lighter, though still creamy, result.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Shahi	Hindi/Urdu for "royal," describing this dish's rich, refined character.
Mughlai	referring to the cuisine of the Mughal era, known for nut-based, aromatic gravies.
Paneer	fresh, non-melting Indian cheese made from curdled milk.
Kesar	Hindi for saffron, sometimes used to finish this dish for color and fragrance.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Shahi Paneer

15m	30m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	**Easy**
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

GRAVY BASE

Cashews	70 g
Onion	150 g
Water	240 ml
Whole spices: green cardamom	2, 3, 1 inch
Ghee or butter	45 g
Ginger-garlic paste	15 g
Tomato puree	45 ml
Kashmiri red chili powder	1.5 g
Sugar	4 g
Salt	6 g

TO FINISH

Paneer	300 g
Heavy cream	60 ml
Silvered almonds	15 g
Saffron strands — optional	a pinch

METHOD

01 **Boil the cashews and onion.** Combine the cashews, roughly chopped onion, and water in a small saucepan.

02 **Blend to a smooth paste.** Let cool slightly, then blend the cashew-onion mixture with the boiling liquid to a completely smooth, pale paste.

03 **Bloom the whole spices.** Heat ghee in a kadai and add the whole cardamom, cloves, and cinnamon stick, letting them sizzle gently for about 30 seconds until fragrant.

04 **Add aromatics and tomato.** Add the ginger-garlic paste to the bloomed whole spices, cooking until fragrant, then stir in the tomato puree and cook for 3–4 minutes until it darkens slightly.

05 **Add the cashew paste.** Pour in the cashew-onion paste, along with the chili powder, sugar, and salt.

06 **Add paneer and cream.** Gently fold in the paneer cubes and simmer for 3–4 minutes until warmed through.

07 **Garnish and serve.** Top with silvered almonds just before serving, for both flavor and the dish's traditional royal presentation.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐	Cashews	70 g	
☐	Whole spices: green cardamom	2, 3, 1 inch	
☐	Ginger-garlic paste	15 g	
☐	Kashmiri red chili powder	1.5 g	
☐	Salt	6 g	
☐	Heavy cream	60 ml	
☐	Saffron strands — optional	a pinch	
☐	Onion	150 g	
☐	Ghee or butter	45 g	
☐	Tomato puree	45 ml	
☐	Sugar	4 g	
☐	Paneer	300 g	
☐	Silvered almonds	15 g	

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